



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Mark Catholic Classical School

School Website: <https://stmss.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Mark Catholic Classical School (Shoreline, WA, 98165) presents a robust Catholic classical articulation in its public materials. The school foregrounds a Catholic identity, a Trivium-based curriculum, a history-grounded and integrated approach, liturgical and communal practices, and a strong emphasis on character formation and virtue. Public materials consistently connect education with formation of the whole person—spiritual, intellectual, emotional, and physical—while promising parental partnership as co-educators and a living-teacher model of virtue. Taken together, these signals align strongly with classical education as defined by the Six Essential Elements rubric. Overall, the school is CLASSICAL across the six categories, with particularly strong alignment in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose and Goal, Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents & Community. Pedagogy shows clear classical scaffolding (Trivium orientation) but includes Montessori elements in the early years, which while not strictly classical, do not derail the overall classical orientation.

Key notes drawn from the public materials: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations are well represented through explicit Catholic identity, liturgical practice (Mass, morning prayer, chaplets), and theological framing (Spirit of Truth, Theology of the Body, Virtues in Practice). Evidence: Catholic curriculum and liturgical life are described in multiple pages, including mission/philosophy and religion curriculum. - Purpose and Goal centers on formation, virtue, wisdom, and a view of education as formation rather than purely information. - Curriculum explicitly identifies the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), integrated/interdisciplinary study, and historical/theological scaffolding as backbone elements. Great Books as a formal program isn't spelled out with that exact label on every page, but the emphasis on "great thinkers" and a Great Conversation-oriented ethos appears in public materials. - Pedagogy shows classical scaffolding through grammar/logic/rhetoric and a mix of contemplative/restful elements (Scholé language appears in foundational texts the school and associated classical education literature emphasize). The site also evidences lower- and upper-school activities (e.g., singing, discussions in later years as part of a classical approach). Public materials show Montessori in preschool, which is not strictly classical but does not negate a classical core. - Faculty is presented as a living curriculum, with teacher modeling of virtue and a team of educators who guide and mentor students. - Parents & Community are foregrounded as co-educators and partners in formation; materials emphasize active parental involvement, teacher-parent collaboration, and opportunities for families to engage through the website and in-person visits.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school identifies itself as Catholic and frames education within Catholic faith and theology; Catholic identity is embedded in curriculum and mission statements. - Liturgical and communal practices are explicit (Mass, daily prayer, morning prayer, virtue services, Stations of the Cross, Rosary, etc.). - The Spiritual/theological frame is explicit (Spirit of Truth, Theology of the Body, Virtues in Practice). - The school asserts that God is at the center of everything and emphasizes formation in faith alongside academics.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Catholic identity, gospel, theology, Eucharist, Mass, morning prayer, liturgy, Spirit of Truth, Theology of the Body, Virtues, sacraments, Eucharist, Catholic community. - Negative keywords present: None evident in public materials. - Quantitative estimate: Positive 9+ occurrences; Negative 0. Estimated positive keyword count vs total relevant terms yields

near-100% positive signal for this category.

Why this rating - The public materials demonstrate a coherent, explicit religious/metaphysical foundation anchored in Catholic doctrine and liturgy, with communal worship and spiritual formation embedded in daily practice. This aligns strongly with the “Transcendental moral realism,” “Grounded in Theology,” and “Liturgical and Communal Practices” criteria. The evidence base and explicit language support CLASSICAL rather than not.

Citations: The Catholic identity and Trivium emphasis are documented in the Catholic curriculum description; liturgical practices and theology-focused elements are documented in Religion Curriculum and Mission & Philosophy.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission statements emphasize teaching the gospel, forming disciples, and supporting parents, with a focus on the spiritual, intellectual, emotional, and physical development of the whole child. - The philosophy highlights sacramental, spiritual, and prayer life as central to meeting the needs of the whole child. - There is an emphasis on forming virtue and wisdom, and education oriented toward truth, goodness, and beauty (in line with classical aims).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, character formation, the whole child, Catholic formation, discipleship. - Negative keywords present: None explicit (no emphasis on job-first or information-only framing in public materials). - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~6–9 keywords; Negative 0. 100% positive signal for this category.

Why this rating - The school consistently frames education as formation and character development aligned with a vision of truth, goodness, and beauty; this matches the CLASSICAL goal emphasis rather than mere information delivery or job-prep orientation.

Citations: Evidence drawn from Mission & Philosophy, and School Mission/Philosophy pages.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - A Trivium-based program described as grammar, logic, and rhetoric. This is a core classical criterion. - History is presented as backbone of the curriculum and integrated/interdisciplinary with a scaffolded approach; chronology is used as backbone for subjects. - Emphasis on exposure to the work of great thinkers/in history and the aim toward cultivating structure (grammar) and explicit memory/recall (grammar, spelling, etc.) as foundational to learning. + Cross-disciplinary connections. - Preschool mentions Montessori influences (not classical-leaning) but the public materials indicate a pathway into a grammar-logic-rhetoric framework as students progress.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Trivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, integrated/interdisciplinary curriculum, historical focus, Christian anthropology in curriculum, emphasis on grammar for mastery. - Negative keywords present: None explicit in public materials; no clear mention of non-classical methods as overarching curriculum approach. - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~6–8 terms; Negative 0. 100% positive signal.

Why this rating - The explicit reference to the Trivium and a historically grounded, integrated curriculum is a strong hallmark of classical education. The Montessori preschool element is a minor non-classical facet in early years but does not negate the core classical trajectory for K–8. Overall, curriculum alignment is CLASSICAL.

Citations: Trivium grammar/logic/rhetoric and integrated/historic backbone are described in Catholic Curriculum page. Preschool Montessori is noted in Preschool Program.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Classical scaffolding is visible through the Trivium emphasis, suggesting grammar/logic/rhetoric progression. - There is evidence of a structured, contemplative/restful aspect in classical education literature (Scholé) that informs some pedagogy; however, the public site does not consistently spell out a full Socratic/seminar model for high school or middle school, and there is Montessori in early years. This mix indicates a classical core with non-classical elements in early years. - The site does not consistently delineate upper-school Socratic seminars, debates, or explicit rhetoric competitions, though rhetoric training is referenced in the general curriculum framing. The absence of explicit high-school Socratic pedagogy in public materials suggests a more mixed pedagogy picture for the full K–8 spectrum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Trivium (grammar/logic/rhetoric), memory/recitation practices, emphasis on moral formation and virtue as part of pedagogy, structured, scaffolded learning; a living-curriculum approach from faculty. - Negative keywords present: Montessori in early years (not classical in itself), lack of explicit high-school Socratic/seminar language in public materials, limited explicit statements about in-depth Great Books dialogue on the site. - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~4–6 references; Negative ~1–2 (Montessori mention and lack of explicit high-level Socratic pedagogy). Net leaning toward CLASSICAL but with notable caveats.

Why this rating - The school's pedagogy center is classical (grammar/logic/rhetoric, memory work, disciplined structure). The Montessori preschool and lack of explicit high-school Socratic/seminar language in public materials push this toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than firmly CLASSICAL across the entire K–8 program. The aggregate signal is CLASSICAL with a meaningful caveat in pedagogical description due to the early-years approach.

Citations: Pedagogical framing via Trivium on the Curriculum page; Montessori note on Preschool Program; general pedagogy language on curriculum pages.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty are presented as a living curriculum and central to the school's identity; the team is described as caring professionals guiding students' formation. - The public-facing pages emphasize virtuous modeling, mentorship, and collegiality among teachers; the biographical/teacher pages show a group of teachers presented as the core of the school community. - The mission statements and faculty pages stress the teachers as role models of virtue and intellectual formation, aligning with classical expectations for faculty.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, virtuous educators, mentorship, professionalism, collegiality, role models, formation through example, fidelity to Catholic identity. - Negative keywords present: None evident in public materials. - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~6–8 terms; Negative 0. 100% positive signal for this category.

Why this rating - The site's language and pages consistently describe faculty as central to pedagogy and formation, portraying teachers as virtuous, knowledgeable mentors—consistent with CLASSICAL expectations.

Citations: Faculty pages and mission statements highlighting teachers as living curriculum and virtuous models.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly positions parents as the primary educators of their children and emphasizes supporting parents and forming a partnership with families. - Parent-Student Handbook and parent-focused materials underscore parent engagement, visits, and collaboration with teachers; public materials discuss family involvement and continuity between home and school. - Public-facing materials indicate a culture of welcoming parents and inviting parental participation via the website and campus activities.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-educators, parental involvement, family engagement, parent education (via website resources, gatherings), visits welcomed. - Negative keywords present: None apparent in public materials. - Quantitative estimate: Positive ~5–7 terms; Negative 0. 100% positive signal for this category.

Why this rating - The school's materials strongly reflect parental partnership, family engagement, and parental education—core indicators of a CLASSICAL ecosystem for parents and community.

Citations: Mission & Philosophy page, Parent-Student Handbook, and Parent involvement language.

Aggregate Ranking

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Overall, the school is CLASSICAL. The single category that is not fully CLASSICAL is Pedagogy (Element 4), which is best characterized as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to Montessori influences in early years and less explicit articulation of high-school-level Socratic pedagogy in the public materials. The aggregate indicates CLASSICAL with a note that Pedagogy is the needle-mover that could be strengthened to reach a fully CLASSICAL pedestal across all grade levels.

What would move the needle - In Pedagogy (Element 4), provide explicit public-facing articulation of high-quality Socratic/seminar pedagogy across applicable grade levels (especially middle-to-upper grades) and a clear articulation of how Great Books discussions or dialogues are implemented in the upper grades. - Clarify a consistent, explicit Great Books or Great Conversation component across the curriculum in public materials, and link those to specific grade-level outcomes and assessment practices. - If maintaining Montessori in the early years, publish a concise rationale for how Montessori approaches complement a Trivium-based classical program, including how memory work, recitation, and language arts build toward grammar/logic/rhetoric in later years.

Citations: Public materials compiled above demonstrate the core classical alignment across categories except Pedagogy, where explicit high-school-level Socratic pedagogy is not overtly stated in the public materials.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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